PATAGONIAN MARA

Dolichotis patagonum

1. What can it see, hear, or feel?
Big eyes and long ears watch flat land far away, and its nose knows its mate and pups.

2. Where does it live — and why?
It lives in open grassland where it can see predators coming from a long way off.

3. How does it send messages?
It leaps high to show strength, and males mark their partner with scent to warn other males.

4. What does it do when something changes?
When danger comes, the male runs out in front, and the pair stays close together.

5. How does it learn?
Pups follow their parents, watch which plants to eat, and learn alarm calls in their first weeks.

6. How does it have babies?
Pairs bond for life and share big dens, but each mother only nurses her own pups.

7. What are its limits?
Dense plants block its view, so loss of open grassland leaves it without food or safety.

8. What does this teach us?
Open space looks empty to us but is full of signals to an animal that lives there.

WHY IS THIS ANIMAL HERE?

Maras live in the dry grasslands of central and southern Argentina.
Their grasslands are being plowed for farming and ranching.
They need wide, open ground to run from predators.

When its habitat shrinks:

- fences and crops cut their grasslands into pieces
- pairs lose the open space they need to raise young
- their wild range keeps shrinking each decade

This place is not their natural home, but it can help keep the species alive.

THINK ABOUT THIS

If you ran fast and bounced like a rabbit, where would you run to feel safe?

What a living thing can sense becomes its reality.
Environment shapes design.

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